

Trimeresurus albolabris

White-lipped pit viper



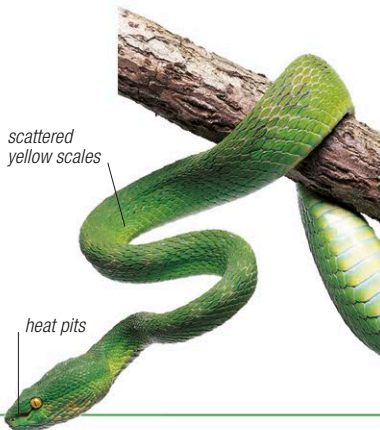
Location S.E. Asia

Length 23½–39 in (60–100 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Least concern



This slender-bodied snake—easily confused with several other green pit vipers from the same part of the world—has a wide, rounded head with prominent heat pits. It lives in trees, hanging head-down at night

in a favored hunting place waiting for prey to come within range, then drawing back its head when ready to strike. Its bite is painful, but the venom is mild and rarely fatal to humans. Females give birth to 10–11 young.



Tropidolaemus wagleri

Wagler's viper



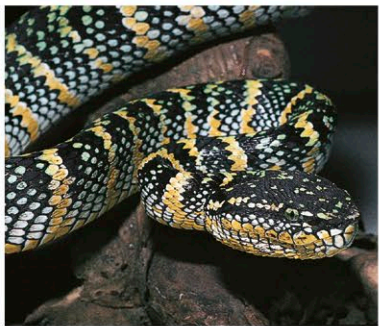
Location S.E. Asia

Length 2½–4¼ ft (0.8–1.3 m)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Least concern



Renowned for living in semicaptivity in Malaysia's Penang Snake Temple, this highly variable snake is sluggish during the day, when it rests in trees. At night, it ambushes small mammals, birds, lizards, and frogs by hanging head-down from the branches. It is a thickset viper, with a chunky head, and

has various color combinations: usually black, with green or yellow crossbars and scattered yellow spots. Juveniles are green, with yellow and/or red spots arranged into vague crossbands; some individuals retain their juvenile markings throughout their lives. Although its bite is painful, it is seldom fatal to humans.

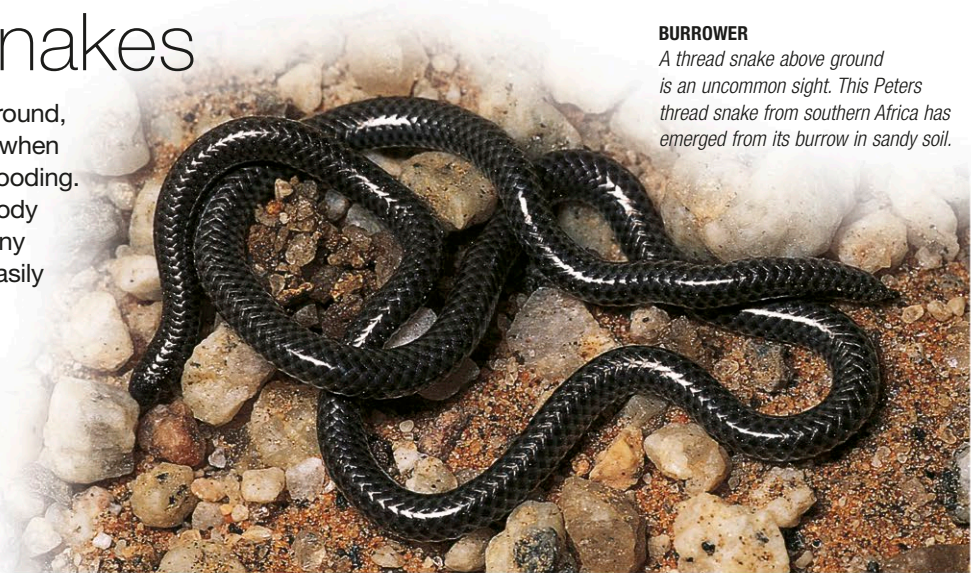


Blind and thread snakes

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Reptilia
ORDER	Squamata
SUBORDER	Serpentes
SUPERFAMILY	Scolecophidia
FAMILIES	5
SPECIES	441

These small snakes live underground, emerging above the surface only when driven out by lack of food or by flooding. They have a slender, cylindrical body and are covered with smooth, shiny scales that allow them to move easily through sand and soil. Their skull is more heavily built than in other snakes, and they have jaws that

they cannot open widely, with few teeth. Their eyes are covered with scales and are barely functional. Blind and thread snakes are restricted to tropical and subtropical regions. They are often found within ant and termite mounds, and the bulk of their diet is composed of these insects and their larvae.



BURROWER
A thread snake above ground is an uncommon sight. This Peters thread snake from southern Africa has emerged from its burrow in sandy soil.

Rena dulcis

Texas thread snake



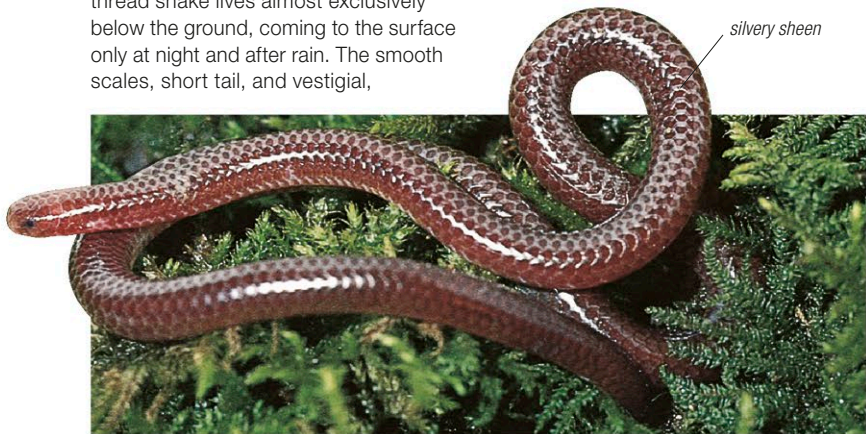
Location S. USA, N.E. Mexico

Length 6–10½ in (15–27 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Burrowing
Status Least concern



The slender-bodied, pinkish brown Texas thread snake lives almost exclusively below the ground, coming to the surface only at night and after rain. The smooth scales, short tail, and vestigial,

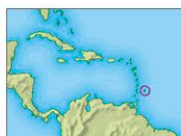
scale-covered eyes are all features associated with a burrowing lifestyle. This snake feeds opportunistically on small insects and spiders, and also enters ant and termite nests in search of larvae. When the snake enters a nest, it releases pheromones that imitate that of the insects. The “soldiers,” deceived into thinking that the snake is part of the nest, allow it to enter and feed in safety. The chief predators of the Texas thread snake are other snakes and nocturnal birds and mammals. The female lays 2–7 eggs and coils around them until they hatch.



silvery sheen

Tetracheilostoma carlae

Barbados thread snake



Location Caribbean

Length Up to 4 in (10 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Burrowing
Status Critically endangered



This tiny snake was described in 2008. It is only found on the upland forest of central Barbados. The larger and recently introduced brahminy thread snake, which breeds more quickly, could be an important competitor and threaten its survival. The Barbados thread snake is the smallest known snake—and has probably evolved to the lowest possible size limit for any snake. It lays a single, highly elongated egg, which hatches into a youngster that is already half the length of an adult snake. A related species found only on St. Lucia island could be the world's second smallest snake.

Indotyphlops braminus

Brahminy blind snake



Location W. Asia to N. Australia. Widely introduced elsewhere

Length 6–7 in (15–18 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Burrowing
Status Not evaluated



This is the only snake known to be parthenogenetic. Males have never been found, and females lay their eggs without having to mate. Each egg is about the size of a peanut. The snake's habit of stowing away in plant pots has resulted in the spread of this species throughout warm parts of the world. Its scale-covered eyes, blunt snout, and smooth scales are all features adapted to burrowing. If in danger, this snake may give off an unpleasant, pungent fluid.

